

AP ENGLISH LANGUAGE & COMPOSITION · THE UNIVERSAL STUDY GUIDE

Targeting a 3, 4, or 5 — every concept tagged for your tier

Tier badges: [3] foundational · [4] adds for 4+ · [5] adds for 5

Targeting a 4 → study [3] AND [4] items. Targeting a 5 → study all three tiers.

PAGE 1 | MATH OF 3/4/5 · 3 ESSAYS · THE 6-POINT RUBRIC

About this exam. AP Lang tests how authors PERSUADE — their rhetorical choices and the effects on audience. Different from AP Lit (which is literature analysis). 45 MCQ + 3 essays in 3 hours 15 min. **All 3 essays use the SAME 6-point rubric:** Thesis (1) + Evidence/Commentary (4) + Sophistication (1). Master that rubric and the same scaffold works across all three.

THE MATH OF YOUR TARGET

Target	MCQ (45q, 45%)	3 Essays (55%)	Approx %	Tier
3 (PASS)	~22 / 45 (~49%)	~3.5 avg / 6 each	~50-55%	[3]
4	~28 / 45 (~62%)	~4.0 avg / 6 each	~62-67%	[3] + [4]
5	~35 / 45 (~78%)	~5.0+ avg / 6 each	~78-83%	All

Time: 60 min for 45 MCQ (~1:20 each), 135 min for 3 essays (~40 min Synthesis + 40 min Rhet Analysis + 40 min Argument). 15-min reading-only period for Synthesis sources.

THE 3 ESSAYS — predictable structure [3]

#	Essay	Time	What it tests
Q1	Synthesis	40 min (15 min reading)	Read 6-7 sources on a topic. Take a position. Use AT LEAST 3 sources to support your argument. Cite each by letter (Source A, Source B, etc.).
Q2	Rhetorical Analysis	40 min	Read a non-fiction passage (speech, letter, essay). Analyze how the author's RHETORICAL CHOICES achieve their PURPOSE.
Q3	Argument	40 min	Read a prompt with a quotation/idea. Take a position + defend it with EVIDENCE FROM YOUR OWN KNOWLEDGE (history, lit, current events, personal experience).

THE UNIVERSAL 6-POINT RUBRIC [3]/[4]/[5]

THESIS: 1 point
Defensible position responding to the prompt. NOT a restatement.

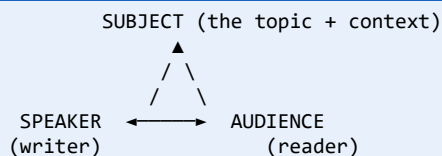
EVIDENCE + COMMENTARY: 4 points (the bulk of the score)
 0 = no evidence
 1 = some evidence, no analysis
 2 = some evidence, some analysis
 3 = specific evidence, consistent analysis explaining HOW evidence supports thesis
 4 = specific evidence + consistent analysis of MULTIPLE points + meaningful commentary

SOPHISTICATION: 1 point
 Earned by ONE of: nuance, complexity, broader context, vivid style.
 THIS IS THE [5] POINT.

KEY INSIGHT [3]/[4] The same rubric across all 3 essays = the same scaffold. Thesis sentence at end of intro → 2-3 body paragraphs each with specific evidence + 2-3 sentences of commentary → conclusion that gestures at significance. Drill this scaffold for each of the 3 essay types.

PAGE 2 | THE RHETORICAL TRIANGLE · SOAPSTone · ETHOS/PATHOS/LOGOS

The foundation of AP Lang. Every passage you analyze is a triangle of speaker, audience, purpose. The author makes choices to bridge these three. Your job: identify the choices and explain WHY they work.

THE RHETORICAL TRIANGLE [3]

The author makes RHETORICAL CHOICES to connect the three.
Your essay explains HOW + WHY those choices work.

SOAPSTone — pre-writing for any passage [3]/[4]

Letter	Stands for + question to ask
S	Speaker — Who is the author? What is their authority/credibility/persona?
O	Occasion — When + where + why is this written? What's the immediate context?
A	Audience — Who is the intended reader? Friendly, hostile, neutral, mixed?
P	Purpose — What does the author want to ACCOMPLISH? Persuade, defend, condemn, unite?
S	Subject — What is the topic + the author's stance on it?
Tone	Tone — What's the author's attitude? (use specific tone words: indignant, reverent, ironic, wry...)

KEY INSIGHT [4] On the Rhetorical Analysis essay, identify SOAPSTone in the **FIRST 3 minutes** (mostly from the prompt's headnote + opening paragraph). This determines what choices to look for + what to argue.

ETHOS · PATHOS · LOGOS [3]

Appeal	What it does + how to spot it
Ethos	Author's CREDIBILITY/CHARACTER. Spotted via: credentials, trustworthiness signals, shared values, humility/authority, professional language.
Pathos	Audience's EMOTIONS. Spotted via: vivid imagery, anecdotes (esp. about children/victims), charged words, urgency, hope/fear language.
Logos	LOGIC + reasoning. Spotted via: data/statistics, cause-effect, deductive reasoning, expert citations, structured arguments.

WATCH OUT [3] Don't just LIST these in your essay. Saying "the author uses pathos" is worth 0 points. You MUST analyze: HOW does the pathos work? WHY does it advance the purpose? Specific quote + effect on audience.

Common tone words [3]/[4] — bring at least 3 to the exam

POSITIVE:	reverent, optimistic, sincere, earnest, exuberant, nostalgic, admiring, jubilant, amused, conciliatory
NEGATIVE:	indignant, condemnatory, scathing, derisive, contemptuous, cynical, melancholy, mournful, scornful, vitriolic
MIXED:	ironic, wry, ambivalent, satirical, didactic, urgent, contemplative, measured, detached, ominous

PAGE 3 | Q2: RHETORICAL ANALYSIS — DEVICE → EFFECT → PURPOSE

Q2 is the most learnable essay. It has a fixed structural recipe. The students who score 5 don't write longer; they write the same sentence shape repeatedly: **device + textual evidence + effect + connection to purpose.**

THE UNIVERSAL Q2 SENTENCE PATTERN [3]/[4]/[5]

In paragraph X, [author] uses [DEVICE] to [EFFECT].
By [quoting/citing] "[evidence]", [author] [creates/establishes/reveals]
[reaction/response] in the audience, which advances [purpose].

EXAMPLE:

"In paragraph 2, Lincoln employs anaphora to reinforce solidarity. By repeating the phrase 'we cannot dedicate' three times, Lincoln transforms a personal acknowledgment into a collective vow, encouraging his fractured audience to identify themselves with the sacred work of the soldiers and the unfinished union – a unification essential to his purpose of healing the nation."

Q2 ESSAY STRUCTURE — 5 paragraphs [3]/[4]**INTRO (3-4 sentences):**

Hook (context about author/era/occasion)

THESIS – defensible claim about what choices the author makes + why

Example: "In her speech, [author] employs [device 1] and [device 2] to [purpose]."

BODY 1: First device + analysis (4-7 sentences)

BODY 2: Second device + analysis (4-7 sentences)

BODY 3: Third device + analysis (4-7 sentences) [optional for [4]/[5]]

CONCLUSION (2-3 sentences):

Restate the rhetorical move at high level.

Gesture at WHY it matters / what it shows about persuasion. [sophistication]

Q2 thesis examples [3]/[4]/[5]**[3] BASIC defensible thesis:**

"In her speech, Wollstonecraft uses logical reasoning and emotional appeals to argue for women's education."

[4] DEFENSIBLE thesis with rhetorical sophistication:

"Wollstonecraft strategically combines reasoned argument with biting irony to expose the absurdity of denying women education and to convince a skeptical male audience to reconsider their assumptions."

[5] NUANCED, complex thesis:

"Wollstonecraft's seemingly conciliatory tone masks a more radical critique: by appealing to her audience's self-interest before their morals, she shifts the burden of proof onto those who would deny women full intellectual citizenship."

KEY INSIGHT [5] What separates the 5 thesis: it identifies a TENSION or LAYERED move. "Seemingly X but actually Y". "Combines X with Y to achieve Z." "Shifts the burden by...". Generic "author uses X and Y" theses cap at 4.

Q2 common devices to know [3]/[4]/[5]

- **Diction [3]** — word choice. Connotation, formality, specificity. Look for charged or unusual word choices.
- **Syntax [3]/[4]** — sentence structure. Short choppy = urgency; long flowing = contemplative; parallel = balance.
- **Imagery [3]** — sensory language. Often visual but also auditory, tactile. Creates emotional resonance.
- **Tone shift [4]/[5]** — moment when speaker's attitude changes. Hugely useful for analysis structure.
- **Anaphora [4]** — repetition at start of clauses ("I have a dream..."). Creates rhythm + emphasis.
- **Juxtaposition [4]** — placing two opposing ideas side-by-side. Reveals tension or hypocrisy.
- **Allusion [4]** — reference to history, religion, literature. Connects audience to shared knowledge.
- **Rhetorical question [3]/[4]** — engages reader's reasoning; implies expected answer.

PAGE 4 | Q1: SYNTHESIS — 6 SOURCES, 1 ARGUMENT

Q1 looks intimidating but is the most learnable for [4]. You're given 6-7 sources (articles, charts, cartoons, op-eds) on a topic. Read them in 15 minutes, take a position, write a 40-min essay using AT LEAST 3 sources to back up YOUR argument.

Q1 essential rules [3]/[4]

- **[3] You MUST take a clear position.** Sitting on the fence = no thesis = -1.
- **[3] Cite at least 3 sources** in body paragraphs. Use parenthetical (Source A) or by name.
- **[3] Sources support YOUR argument** — they're not the subject. Don't summarize them.
- **[4] Quality over quantity** — 3 well-used sources beats 5 surface mentions.
- **[4] Engage with COUNTER-source** for sophistication. "While Source D argues X, the more compelling case is Y because..."

Q1 reading + planning (15 min) [3]/[4]

MIN 1-2: Read PROMPT carefully. Underline the question/position to take.

MIN 3-13: Read 6-7 sources. For EACH:

- 1-2 word annotation: "PRO X" or "CON X" or "BOTH SIDES"
- Underline 1 specific quote/data point you might use

MIN 14-15: Decide thesis + pick 3 sources to support + 1 to engage as counter.

KEY: Don't read deeply at first. Skim for the source's POSITION.

You can re-read closely once you know your thesis.

Q1 essay structure [3]/[4]

INTRO:

Brief context on the topic (1-2 sentences).

Thesis: take a clear, defensible position.

"While [counter-position] has some merit, [your position] is more compelling because [reason 1] and [reason 2]."

BODY 1: Reason 1 supported by Source X + Source Y.

Source X provides [data/argument] that shows [point].

This evidence demonstrates that [your reason] because...

BODY 2: Reason 2 supported by Source Z.

Source Z's [example/quote] reinforces this by...

BODY 3 (for [4]/[5]): Address counter-argument.

Source D presents the opposing view... however, this overlooks...

CONCLUSION: Restate position + broader implication.

KEY INSIGHT [5] The synthesis sophistication move. Don't just use sources — make them TALK to each other. "Source A's optimism about technology is undercut by Source C's data showing actual usage decline. Together, they suggest that..." Sources interacting = sophistication credit.

PAGE 5 | Q3: ARGUMENT — YOUR EVIDENCE BANK

Q3 has no sources. Just a prompt + a quote/idea. You take a position and support it with evidence FROM YOUR OWN MEMORY — history, current events, literature, personal experience. The students who score 5 walk in with a pre-loaded evidence bank.

Q3 essay structure [3]/[4]**INTRO:**

Engage the prompt's question/idea.
Thesis: clearly state your position.

BODY 1: Specific example #1 (named, dated, detailed)
State the example, explain the relevant facts, link to thesis.

BODY 2: Specific example #2 (different DOMAIN – if #1 was history, try lit)
Same recipe.

BODY 3 (for [4]/[5]): Acknowledge complication or counter; resolve.

CONCLUSION: Why this matters now / broader principle.

Pre-loaded evidence bank [3]/[4]/[5]

Walk in with these. Memorize 2-3 specific facts about each so you can summon them under time pressure for any prompt.

Domain	Pre-load these
US history	Civil Rights Movement (Rosa Parks, Birmingham, Selma); New Deal/FDR; Women's suffrage (Seneca Falls); Vietnam War + protests; Watergate; 1965 Voting Rights Act
World history	Mandela + apartheid; Berlin Wall (1989); Tiananmen Square; Gandhi + nonviolence; Holocaust + Anne Frank; Arab Spring
Literature	Atticus Finch (To Kill a Mockingbird); Winston (1984); Hester Prynne (Scarlet Letter); Holden (Catcher in the Rye); Beloved (Morrison); Macbeth
Tech / current events	Social media + mental health; ChatGPT/AI ethics; climate activism (Greta Thunberg); MLK "I Have a Dream"; #MeToo; Black Lives Matter
Science	Galileo + Inquisition; Curie's persistence; Watson/Crick (DNA); Jonas Salk + polio vaccine; SpaceX/Apollo 11
Personal experience	1-2 specific moments (don't fabricate; pick real, detailed ones — losing a game, advocating for a friend, witnessing a moral choice)

WATCH OUT [3]/[4] DON'T fabricate quotes or specific facts you don't know. Graders catch this. Better to use a slightly less precise but accurate example than a fake "specific" one.

Q3 thesis types — match the prompt [4]/[5]

PROMPT TYPE 1: "Defend, challenge, or qualify [claim]."
Best 5: QUALIFY (rarely defend or challenge outright).
"While [claim] holds true in [context], it overlooks [exception]..."

PROMPT TYPE 2: "Take a position on [issue]."
Pick the position you have BEST evidence for, not necessarily what you believe.

PROMPT TYPE 3: "Discuss the role/value of [concept]."
Make a NUANCED claim — "X is essential when Y, but harmful when Z."

PAGE 6 | RHETORICAL DEVICE TOOLKIT — 25 NAMED MOVES

Schemes (sentence patterns) [3]/[4]/[5]

Device	Definition + spotting hint
Anaphora [4]	Repetition at START of successive clauses. "We shall fight on the beaches; we shall fight on the landing grounds..."
Epistrophe [5]	Repetition at END of successive clauses. "...government of the people, by the people, for the people."
Anadiplosis [5]	End of one clause becomes start of next. "Suffering breeds character; character breeds faith..."
Asyndeton [4]	Omitting conjunctions for speed. "I came, I saw, I conquered."
Polysyndeton [4]	Extra conjunctions for weight. "...and the lions and the tigers and the bears..."
Antithesis [4]	Sharp contrast in parallel structure. "Ask not what your country can do for you, but what you can do for your country."
Chiasmus [5]	Reversed parallel (ABBA). "Fair is foul, and foul is fair."
Parallelism [3]/[4]	Repeated grammatical structure. Creates rhythm + balance.

Tropes (figurative language) [3]/[4]/[5]

Device	Definition + spotting hint
Metaphor [3]	Direct comparison without "like/as". "The classroom was a battlefield."
Simile [3]	Comparison with "like/as". "Her words cut like a knife."
Personification [3]/[4]	Giving human qualities to non-humans. "The wind whispered."
Hyperbole [3]	Extreme exaggeration. Often comedic or for emphasis.
Understatement [4]	Saying less than is meant. "It was a bit windy" (during a hurricane). Often ironic.
Irony [3]/[4]/[5]	Verbal: meaning opposite of stated. Situational: opposite of expected. Dramatic: audience knows what character doesn't.
Allusion [4]	Reference to history/lit/myth. Builds shared meaning.
Synecdoche / Metonymy [5]	Part for whole / associated thing. "The crown decided" (= the king).
Apostrophe [5]	Direct address to absent person/abstraction. "O Death, where is thy sting?"

Argumentative moves [4]/[5]

Move	What it does
Concession	Acknowledging counter-argument: "While critics argue X..."
Refutation	Rebutting the concession: "...this view fails to account for Y."
Anecdote	Brief illustrative story. Strongest opener for emotional engagement.
Analogy	Extended comparison to clarify a complex idea. "Climate change is like a slow-rising fever."
Appeal to authority	Citing experts, institutions. Builds ethos via expertise.
Statistical evidence	Numbers/percentages. Builds logos.

KEY INSIGHT [5] Don't memorize 25 devices to NAME — memorize the 8-10 you'll actually USE in essays. Anaphora, juxtaposition, antithesis, irony, allusion, anecdote, concession/refutation, parallelism. These cover virtually every passage on the exam.

PAGE 7 | MCQ STRATEGY · QUESTION TYPES · TIMING

45 questions in 60 minutes ≈ 80 sec each. 5 passages with ~9 questions each. Mix of READING comprehension + WRITING/composition (revising hypothetical drafts).

MCQ question types [3]/[4]

Type	Strategy
"What is the function of [phrase]" [3]	Look at what comes BEFORE and AFTER. Function = how it CONNECTS to the surrounding argument. Often = transition, qualifier, exemplification.
"What does [word] most nearly mean" [3]	Substitute each option into the sentence. Pick the one that fits both grammar AND meaning. Don't pick the dictionary definition out of context.
"What rhetorical strategy does the author use" [3]/[4]	Re-read the sentence. Match it to a NAMED device (anaphora, juxtaposition, etc.). The right answer's strategy will appear in the text.
"How does [paragraph X] develop the argument" [4]	Identify the function: introduce evidence, complicate the claim, anticipate objection, summarize. Pick the answer matching that role.
"In context, the author's tone is best described as" [4]	Re-read for SPECIFIC word choices. Eliminate extreme tones unless clearly there. Look for nuanced answers ("resigned" vs "angry").
"Which revision would best..." (composition Qs) [4]	Read the original + each revision. Choose the one that achieves the SPECIFIED goal (clarity, transition, conciseness, tone). Don't pick "best writing" generically.

MCQ trap-spotting [3]/[4]/[5]

- [3] Eliminate **EXTREME** answers with words like "always," "never," "completely" — usually wrong on rhetorical Qs.
- [3] Eliminate **OFF-TOPIC** answers that mention things outside the passage.
- [4] **Two close answers**: pick the more **PRECISE** one. AP rewards specificity.
- [4] **"All of the above" / "none of the above"** are rare. Don't default to them — re-read.
- [5] **Composition questions** (revision): identify the **SPECIFIC GOAL** the question names. The right answer addresses **ONLY** that goal — even if another option "sounds better."

MCQ time strategy [3]/[4]

60 min total / 5 passages = ~12 min / passage
 Within each passage: ~3-4 min reading, ~8-9 min answering 9 questions

IF STUCK on a question: skip + flag. Come back at end.
 Don't sink 3+ minutes on one question. Better to guess + move + return.

ANSWER EVERY QUESTION — no penalty for wrong. Random guess = 25%, free EV.

PAGE 8 | EARNING THE SOPHISTICATION POINT — THE 5 BAR

Sophistication is the single point that turns a 4 into a 5. Many students earn the thesis + 4 evidence/commentary points but cap there. The sophistication point requires ONE of four moves — and most students try none.

THE 4 PATHS TO SOPHISTICATION [5]

Path	What it looks like
1. Crafting nuanced argument	Acknowledge tensions, complications, exceptions. "While X is true generally, the case of Y suggests..." . Avoid black-and-white claims.
2. Recognizing complexity	Show that an issue or rhetorical move has MULTIPLE layers — not just one effect. "This appeal to pathos simultaneously unifies the audience AND alienates skeptics, a tension Lincoln navigates by..."
3. Connecting to broader context	Link the passage/topic to historical period, cultural moment, philosophical tradition. Not just "this matters today" — be specific. "Wollstonecraft's 1792 challenge anticipated the suffrage movement that followed..."
4. Vivid + persuasive style	Crisp prose, varied sentence rhythm, careful word choice, fluent transitions. The HARDEST path to score reliably; don't rely on it alone.

Sophistication moves to PRACTICE [4]/[5]

PHRASES that signal sophistication:

"While X holds in [context], the more compelling case is..."

"This passage's apparent simplicity belies a deeper tension between..."

"By [device], the author both [effect 1] AND [effect 2] — a strategic doubling."

"In the broader tradition of [movement/era], this argument..."

"What seems like X is actually the surface of Y."

AVOID:

Hedging without commitment ("maybe..." "sort of..." "could be...")

Throwaway broadening ("in today's world..." "throughout history...")

Repetition of thesis without development

KEY INSIGHT [5] The conclusion is your sophistication launchpad. A typical [3] conclusion repeats the intro. A [5] conclusion gestures at IMPLICATIONS or COMPLICATIONS — "This rhetorical move illuminates a broader truth about how persuasion works in..." . Plan 2-3 "big idea" sentences to deploy regardless of prompt.

PAGE 9 | TOP MISTAKES · POINT KILLERS · TIME RECOVERY**Mistakes that cap your score at 3 [3]/[4]**

- **Summarizing instead of analyzing.** "The author says X, then says Y, then concludes Z." Earns 0 commentary points. ANALYZE = explain HOW + WHY a choice works, not just WHAT happened.
- **No defensible thesis.** "This passage is about Lincoln's speech." Restating prompt = no thesis point.
- **Listing devices without analyzing.** "The author uses ethos, pathos, and logos." Earns 0 unless explained.
- **Vague evidence ("the author talks about freedom").** Need quotes or specific paraphrased details.
- **Forgetting to take a position on Q1 or Q3.** "Both sides have merit" without commitment = no thesis.

Mistakes that cap your score at 4 [4]/[5]

- **Only 1-2 sources cited on Q1.** Need 3+ sources used substantively for evidence cap.
- **Generic commentary** ("this makes the audience feel sympathetic"). Be SPECIFIC — what KIND of sympathy? Toward whom? Why does that advance the purpose?
- **No counter-argument** in argumentative essays. Sophistication usually requires engaging an opposing view.
- **Same sentence rhythm + structure throughout.** Style point eluded by monotone prose.
- **Concluding with restatement.** Sophistication conclusion gestures at significance, complication, or broader principle.

If you're running out of time [3]/[4]

PRIORITY ORDER if you have <10 min left on an essay:

1. Make sure THESIS is defensible + clear (1 point)
2. Make sure you have 2 SPECIFIC evidence pieces (max evidence)
3. Add 2-3 sentences of COMMENTARY explaining HOW evidence supports thesis
4. Quick conclusion (even 1 sentence – better than no conclusion)

DON'T: Try to cram in 3 body paragraphs at the cost of analysis.

A focused 2-paragraph essay with strong analysis beats a thin 4-paragraph one.

Common Q2 (Rhet Analysis) trap [4]

Don't get stuck listing devices line-by-line. Pick 2-3 BIG rhetorical moves that organize the entire passage and analyze each across multiple paragraphs. Tracking minor devices line-by-line costs time + earns less than deep analysis of a few key moves.

PAGE 10 | SCORE LADDER · TIER CHECKLISTS · THE ONE THING

THE SCORE LADDER

For a 3 (Pass)	For a 4	For a 5
MCQ: 22-26 / 45	MCQ: 28-32 / 45	MCQ: 35-40 / 45
Defensible thesis on each essay.	Thesis with rhetorical sophistication; specific verbs (challenges, qualifies, exposes).	Thesis identifies tension or layered move.
2 specific pieces of evidence per body para; some commentary.	Evidence + 2-3 sentences explaining HOW it supports thesis.	Evidence + commentary linking to author's broader strategy + complication.
Q1: cite 2-3 sources to support position.	Q1: cite 3+ sources; use them for argument, not summary.	Q1: sources interact with each other; engage counter-source.
Q2: identify 2-3 named devices + brief effect.	Q2: device → effect → purpose chain in every body para.	Q2: organize around 2-3 BIG moves spanning paragraphs.
Q3: clear position + 2 specific examples.	Q3: position + counter + 3 examples from varied domains.	Q3: nuanced position; sophisticated qualification.

TIER-SPECIFIC TEST-DAY CHECKLISTS

For a 3 — focus only on these:

- ✓ MCQ: 22+ correct.
- ✓ Each essay has a clear THESIS — one sentence taking a defensible position.
- ✓ Each body paragraph has SPECIFIC evidence (quote or named example).
- ✓ Some commentary explains how evidence connects to thesis.
- ✓ Q1: cite at least 3 sources by letter.
- ✓ Don't summarize — ANALYZE.

For a 4 — add these on top:

- ✓ MCQ: 28+ correct.
- ✓ Q2 thesis names rhetorical strategies with strong verbs (challenges, qualifies, exposes).
- ✓ Device → effect → purpose chain in every body paragraph of Q2.
- ✓ Engage with counter-position in Q1 + Q3 (concession + refutation).
- ✓ 2-3 sentences of commentary per piece of evidence.
- ✓ Specific tone words (not just "angry" — "indignant," "resigned," "wry").

For a 5 — add these on top:

- ✓ MCQ: 35+ correct.
- ✓ Sophistication: nuance, complexity, broader context, OR vivid style.
- ✓ Q2 thesis identifies a TENSION or LAYERED move ("seemingly X, actually Y").
- ✓ Q1: sources INTERACT ("Source A's optimism is undercut by Source C's data").
- ✓ Q3: thesis QUALIFIES rather than fully defends/challenges.
- ✓ Conclusion gestures at broader principle or implication.
- ✓ Crisp prose with varied sentence rhythm.

THE ONE THING THAT MATTERS MOST [3][4][5]: ANALYZE, DON'T SUMMARIZE. Every piece of AP Lang scoring rewards students who explain HOW + WHY a rhetorical choice works to advance the author's purpose. Students who summarize the passage ("the author talks about X, then Y") cap at 3. Students who name a choice + cite evidence + explain its effect on audience + connect to purpose break into 4-5 territory. **Every body paragraph should answer: "So what?" Why does this choice matter to the author's argument?**

If you do nothing else: master the 6-point rubric, drill the device→effect→purpose sentence, and chase the sophistication point with one of the four named paths.

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